Asad Ikram: notes for referees, CSH Vienna PhD (Digital Innovation School, 2027 cohort)

A reminder of facts you may find useful. Please use only what you can personally speak to.

How to submit (from CSH's instructions, attached)

- Email the letter to **applications@csh.ac.at**
- Subject line: **DIS PhD - Asad Ikram**
- PDF, on institutional letterhead, **signed and dated**
- Deadline: **1 November 2026** (midnight Vienna time). CSH confirms receipt.
- A general PhD reference letter is fine; CSH also welcomes answers to the five questions below.

Status: I passed the eligibility check and preliminary review, and completed the recorded preliminary interview on 20 October.

What CSH says it looks for

- Self-directed, independent and intellectually curious
- Rigour and depth
- Engages beyond their own field; enjoys collaboration
- Aims for real-world impact

CSH's five questions, with facts that may help

1. What makes the student unique?
Eight years working with social media data in industry (multilingual scrapers across 15 markets at Dubizzle Labs; social listening for global brands and UK government at M+C Saatchi Fluency; co-founder and CTO of Artemis AI), combined with a research question that came from his own MSc. Chevening Scholar; MSc Data Analytics with Distinction (University of Portsmouth, 2025).

2. Persistence when a project was challenging?
In the MSc (255,446 comments from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora; VADER, BiLSTM and fine-tuned BERT), he found after submission that his validation was circular: BERT had been trained and checked against VADER's own labels. Rather than leave it, he turned the flaw into a methods paper with Dr Haig, *Is the Platform Part of the Measurement?* (arXiv, October 2026), written while working full time.

3. An intellectual strength; how he approaches problems?
He asks where the yardstick comes from. The paper borrows tools from survey research (generalizability theory, measurement invariance and DIF, score linking), fixes 15 anchor events in advance before looking at any counts, and includes a Python simulation with known ground truth (naive pooling gets the direction of daily sentiment wrong on 13.8 of 60 days; adjusted, 0.8).

4. Communication and collaboration?
Co-authored the paper with his supervisor; works with analysts, engineers and client teams at Fluency; leads the technical team at Artemis AI; previously led a team of engineers at Dubizzle Labs.

5. Environment where he will thrive?
A structured programme with clear milestones, an interdisciplinary group, and close mentorship in methods he has not yet trained in (network science of diffusion, causal inference). CSH's government and industry exchanges match his aim of making social media measurement trustworthy for public bodies.

His proposed PhD focus (for context)

When AI-labelled opinion from social media (sentiment, stance, narrative frames) can be compared across platforms, AI models and time, and how correcting it changes conclusions about how narratives spread. Closest CSH fit: Alexander Hoyle (NLP measurement and validation), Elisa Omodei, Fariba Karimi; springboard projects "Understanding narratives at scale" and "Polarization and minority representation on online platforms".